

KING OF CAMBODIA (1922–2012)

NORODOM SIHANOUK

Sihanouk became Cambodia's king in 1941, aged 18. He abdicated after independence but continued to lead the country as prime minister and later as head of state. Observing strict neutrality during the Vietnam War, he was overthrown in a US-backed coup in 1970. Through the subsequent civil war he experienced arrest and exile, before returning to restore national unity in 1991. In 1993, the monarchy was revived and Sihanouk became king for a second time.



» AFTER

Cambodia and Laos were soon swept up in America's crusade against communism.

THE HO CHI MINH TRAIL

By 1960, Laos was in the frontline of the Cold War. North Vietnam occupied parts of Laos in order to create the **Ho Chi Minh Trail**, the supply route for communist forces in South Vietnam. It also supported the insurgency by Laotian communist Pathet Lao guerrillas.

The United States stepped up its intervention in Laos. A second Geneva Conference in 1961–62 declared Laos neutral but had no lasting effect. Civil war continued with covert American involvement. The US Air Force subjected eastern Laos, site of the Ho Chi Minh Trail, to the most sustained **bombing campaign in history**.

RISE OF THE KHMER ROUGE

In Cambodia, Norodom Sihanouk strove to maintain his country's **neutrality**, refusing American military aid. However, he could not stop Vietnamese communist forces from occupying base areas along the border with South Vietnam. In 1970, **a coup by General Lon Nol overthrew Sihanouk**. The United States poured in arms to the new government and bombed Cambodian border regions. The country became a battlefield, with Cambodian communist **Khmer Rouge guerrillas** dominating extensive areas.